



WANTED AN INDIAN FBI

Terrorism is now pan-Indian and requires a campaign by Central and state agencies

The Jaipur blasts came in the wake of claims by intelligence agencies and the police in different states of having neutralised a number of terrorist cells. The fact that this neutralisation did not come in the way of the blasts in Jaipur is a disturbing indicator that we have been dealing with the tip of an iceberg. For every terrorist arrested, there are many waiting to strike.

Terrorism of the past was regional in nature. Its activities were confined to a state. Terrorism today is pan-Indian in nature as the terrorists keep moving from state to state looking for weak points in the security set-up which they can exploit. It is a pan-Indian threat, which calls for a pan-Indian response. The response has to be in the form of a joint campaign in which the Central and state intelligence, security agencies and the police of different states will work together under a common command and control based in New Delhi.

In 2004, the current government created two posts of National Security Advisers (NSA)—one for external security, which was held by the late J.N. Dixit, and the other for internal security, which is held by M.K. Narayanan. After Dixit passed away in January 2005, the Government reverted back to having a single NSA to deal with internal and external security. A reversion to the 2004 practice of having an NSA exclusively for internal security should be the second step for improving our counter-terrorism management.

The third step should be the reorganisation of the Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA). While the trend in other countries has been towards having a single ministry or department to deal exclu-

sively with counter-terrorism, MHA has resisted this. In any unified command and control for counter-terrorism, the ministry responsible for counter-terrorism has to play a pivotal role. The importance of having a single leader for dealing exclusively with internal security, without being burdened with other responsibilities was realised by former prime ministers Rajiv Gandhi and Narasimha Rao. Instead of bifurcating the MHA, Gandhi created a post of minister of state for internal security to handle all operational matters including waging a campaign against terrorism by the Centre and the states. The time has come to create

an independent ministry of internal security.

Preventive intelligence and physical security, and a thorough investigation and prosecution of terrorism-related cases are the essential components of counter-terrorism. Every successful terrorist strike speaks of an intelligence failure. But there is a lack of co-ordination not only among the agencies at the Centre, but also between the Central agencies and the state police. How to improve the quantity and quality of the intelligence flow? How to ensure better coordination between the Centre and the states? Important questions such as these were addressed by the Special Task Force for Revamping the Intelligence Apparatus headed by G.C. Saxena, former head of the Research and Analysis Wing (RAW). The implementation of its recommendations has not had the desired impact on the ground. Why? What further measures are needed? These issues have to be urgently addressed by a dedicated task force on terrorism-related intelligence capabilities.

Preventive physical security is the responsibility of Central police forces and the police of different states. While the capability at the Centre has improved, it has improved in certain states and declined in certain others. A strong physical security capability can thwart a terrorist strike even in the absence of intelligence. A weak capability may not be able to prevent it even if intelligence is available. Identification of weaknesses in our physical security set-up and action to remove them must receive priority.

Successful investigation and prosecution deter future attacks. Poor investigation and prosecution encourage terrorism. India has a poor record in successful prosecutions. Effective co-ordination of the police in all the states, the creation of a national database to which the police of different states can have direct access and quick sharing of investigations could improve our record here. The creation of a federal counter-terrorism agency patterned after the Federal Bureau of Investigation of the US, with powers to investigate all terrorism-related cases occurring in any part of the country, would facilitate action and prevention, but there is a strong resistance from the states to proposals for the creation of such an agency.

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